

Adarsh Pillai

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PROFILE

Cybersecurity student focused on offensive security and reverse engineering. Co-founder of the **404squad** CTF team; I organize our near-weekly competitions and mainly solve misc and rev challenges. **TryHackMe top 2% globally** (100+ rooms completed).

Built and operate **Threat Harbour**, a live Cowrie SSH honeypot on Oracle Cloud that has logged **760K+ attack events from 4,923 unique IPs** and republishes an aggregate threat-intel leaderboard every 24h. Author of **22 published CTF writeups** plus public lab notes and security tooling.

EDUCATION

Placid Vidya Vihar Senior Secondary School Changanassery, Kerala
Class XII, CBSE (Classes XI–XII) – expected completion Mar. 2027 2025 – 2027

Amrita Vidyalayam Vazhappally West, Kottayam, Kerala
Class X, CBSE (Classes IX–X) 2023 – 2025

Earlier schooling: *Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan Senior Secondary School, Thirunavaya, Malappuram (Class VIII, 2022–23); Raja Narayanlal Lahoti English School (RNLES), Latur, Maharashtra (Classes I–VII, to 2022)*

EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder & Core Member, 404squad (CTF Team) 2026 – Present
Competitive Capture The Flag Remote, India

- One of three co-founders of 404squad; run the team's near-weekly competition cycle — scheduling, challenge triage across web/pwn/rev/crypto/forensics, and post-event writeup reviews.
- Primary solver on misc and reverse engineering; cross-train teammates and keep a shared methodology so results repeat.
- Write up every competition publicly so teammates and readers can reproduce each solve step by step.

Independent Security Researcher & Technical Writer 2021 – Present
Self-directed research, CTFs and lab work Remote

- Publish **22 detailed CTF writeups** (Hacker Holidays 2026, pwnable.kr, picoCTF, TryHackMe) covering web, pwn, rev, crypto, forensics, cloud and OSINT — every step, command and its output, with concept explanations.
- Maintain public lab-note repositories for **100+ TryHackMe rooms**, picoCTF and TCM's Practical Ethical Hacking: enumeration, exploitation path, and what would have stopped it.
- Run an automated publishing pipeline (Python generators + daily GitHub Actions) that turns Markdown into static writeup, blog and threat-intel sites with search, auto category tags and source-grounded difficulty badges.

PROJECTS

Threat Harbour | *Cowrie, Python, Oracle Cloud, Grafana/Loki, GitHub Actions* Aug. 2026 – Present

- Deployed and hardened a **Cowrie 3.0.13 SSH honeypot** on an OCI Free Tier VM (ap-hyderabad-1): single exposed port, NSG rules, restricted read-only SSH operator account, localhost-bound monitoring never exposed publicly.
- Built a **daily 00:00 UTC pipeline** that SSHes to the sensor, runs a stdlib-only parser on-box and commits only aggregates — raw logs, source IPs, payloads and keys never leave the machine; out-of-band OCI API reboot handles a wedged sshd.
- Instrumented the sensor with **Grafana + Loki + Promtail** (SSH-tunnel only) and gated every publish on a fail-loud **pytest** suite with GitHub Actions CI.
- **760,104 events / 4,923 unique IPs / 110,633 sessions** analyzed to date. Median session 2.4s; 94% of commands are recon or fingerprinting, with repeated persistence attempts against authorized_keys. Findings are written up in the research docs.
- Published a public **intel dashboard** (KPIs, timeline, credential/command leaderboards) rebuilt daily from the same metrics, plus machine-readable **metrics.json** feed.

Security Automation Toolkit | *Python, Bash*

Jul. 2026 – Present

- Wrote a set of small CLI utilities for repetitive assessment work: port scanner, subdomain hunter, hash cracker, DNS scanner, host-to-IP resolver, IP tracker and WordPress content discovery.
- Shell tooling for **recon and web application enumeration** (service and version sweeps, content brute-forcing), documented with usage examples for CTF and lab use.

Security Portfolio & Publishing Platform | *HTML, CSS, JS, Python*

Aug. 2026 – Present

- Shipped a static security portfolio with a command palette, repository file browser, inline file viewer, strict CSP, JSON-LD structured data and live GitHub API repo cards — no framework, no backend.
- Authored three Python generators (writeups, blog, threat intel) that render Markdown/metrics into SEO-ready static sites with search indexes, tags and difficulty badges.
- Automated delivery with scheduled GitHub Actions (daily + on-push, cross-repo repository dispatch) so new writeups and sensor data appear with zero manual steps.

COMPETITIVE RESULTS

Lun4R CTF 2026 <i>qualifiers</i> — 404squad: #2 overall	<i>proof</i>
PwnSec CTF 2026 — 404squad: #6 human division, 237 teams	<i>proof</i>
Lun4R CTF 2026 <i>finals</i> — 404squad: #9 overall	<i>proof</i>
z0d1ak CTF 2026 — 404squad: #13 human, #75 overall	<i>proof</i>
TFC CTF 2026 — 404squad: #23 human, #172 overall	<i>proof</i>
H7CTF 2026 — 404squad: #58 overall	<i>proof</i>
TryHackMe — top 2% globally, 100+ rooms completed	<i>profile</i>
pwnable.kr — Toddler's Bottle; picoCTF — heap and rev; Hacker Holidays 2026 — all 15 rooms	

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Security: Web Exploitation, Network Security, Reverse Engineering, Binary Exploitation (pwn), OSINT, Threat Intelligence, Honeypot Operations
Tools: Burp Suite, ffuf, Nuclei, Nikto, sqlmap, Nmap, Wireshark, Ghidra, Binary Ninja, pwntools, pwndbg, Autopsy, Binwalk
Languages: Python, Bash, C, SQL, Go
Platforms: Linux, Docker, Git, GitHub Actions, Oracle Cloud (OCI), Grafana, Loki
Currently Learning: Forensics, Cloud, Assembly, Blockchain

CERTIFICATES & TRAINING

PwnSec CTF 2026 — 6th, human division of 237 teams	<i>verify</i>
Lun4R CTF 2026 <i>finals</i> — 404squad, 9th	<i>verify</i>
Lun4R CTF 2026 <i>qualifiers</i> — 404squad, 2nd	<i>verify</i>
H7CTF 2026 — 404squad, 58th	<i>verify</i>
z0d1ak CTF 2026 — 404squad, 75th	<i>verify</i>
TFC CTF 2026 — 404squad, 172nd	<i>verify</i>
Hacker Holidays — TryHackMe, 2026	<i>verify</i>
Advent of Cyber 3 — TryHackMe, 2021	<i>verify</i>
Practical Ethical Hacking — TCM Security, 2021	<i>verify</i>